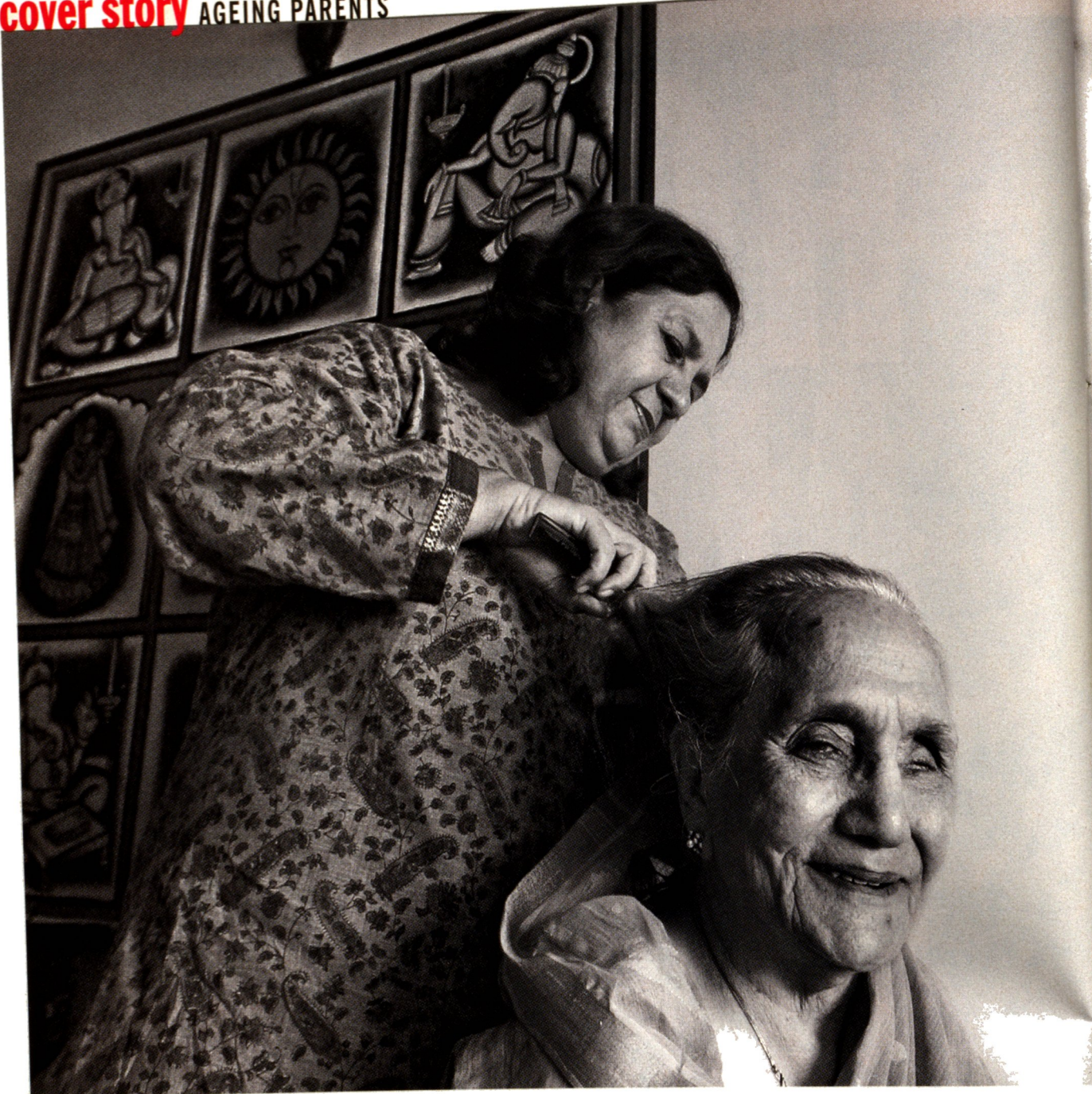




BHASKAR PAUL

She's hardly the only one. It has become this generation's latest, and in some ways most agonising, life crisis: what to do when the parents who once took care of you can no longer look after themselves? The age-wave is mounting. With one elderly in every 12, India is poised to become the second largest hub of seniors in the world. There are eight million aged over 80, 29 million 70-plus and 77 million above 60. In urban areas, 64 per cent elderly women and 46 per cent men are fully dependent—for food, clothing and healthcare—on others. About 10 per

cent do not have anyone to take care of them. The number of elderly, ill and in need of care, is over 27 million.

Consider Delhi's Daljit Singh and Swarn Mongia. Their three daughters live in the US and e-mails have become a way of life. At least, ever since their parents decided to return the Green Cards, sell off the Panchsheel Park flat and settle down in a home for the aged at Dwarka. They were upset ("Why do you have to go and settle down in an ashram?"). But after 10 years of toing and froing between India and the US, enough was enough for them.

"We didn't want a life of total dependence on children," says Mongia, 82. "There, we had no friends our age, too," adds his wife, 78. There is no dearth of companionship now. At dusk, as fellow residents gather in their comfortable room, the children, too, keep them company—from the massive gilded photo collage on the wall capturing every landmark in their 59 years of togetherness.

"In a country famous for taking care of its old, there is an urgent talk of the greying of India," stresses economist C.P. Chandrasekhar of Jawaharlal